

COMPARE AND CONTRAST, WITH EVIDENCE

# Freud and Lasch on Religion, Illusion, and Modernity

Sigmund Freud, *The Future of an Illusion* (1927) · Christopher Lasch, *The Illusion of Disillusionment* (1991)

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Lasch's speech is a direct reply to Freud's book. He borrows Freud's title, quotes him by name, and ends by turning the phrase "the future of an illusion" against him. That makes the two readings unusually easy to set side by side. This document states each point of comparison as a claim, then places the evidence from both texts next to it. Paragraph numbers (F¶ and L¶) match the class handouts, the quiz site, and the two study guides.

Structure: (1) the shared ground the argument stands on, (2) the disagreements, (3) how the two can be made to work together, (4) a one-page reference table.

## The argument in one paragraph each

### FREUD

Religion is a body of dogmas that demand belief without offering the kind of evidence we require everywhere else (F¶1–5). The attempts to excuse this, "believe because it is absurd" and "behave as if it were true," fail (F¶6–7). What actually sustains religion is wish: the helpless child's need for a protecting father, projected onto the universe as providence, moral order, and afterlife (F¶8). Such wish-driven beliefs are illusions, not necessarily false but unsupported (F¶9–10). Honest people should admit that a world arranged exactly as we would wish it is suspicious (F¶11–12).

### LASCH

Modern thinkers, Freud among them, tell history as a life story: humanity outgrew the childish faith of the past and now faces reality disillusioned (L¶1–3). This is a myth, and a proud one; progress-worship and nostalgia are its two faces, and both declare the past dead (L¶4–8). The myth misreads religion as comfort and simple rules, when in fact faith has always arisen from despair and confronted evil (L¶9–12). True faith does not fulfil our wishes; it demands we surrender the wish to control the universe (L¶13–14). What is really modern is a rebellion against dependence licensed by science, and the illusion of mastery is the one whose future is in doubt (L¶15–16).

## 1. Shared ground

The disagreement is sharp only because the two men agree about so much. Four points of agreement come first, because Lasch's whole strategy is to accept Freud's premises and reverse his conclusion.

**Both define religion by its relation to human helplessness and dependence.**

AGREE

Neither author thinks religion is primarily a set of rituals or a philosophy. For both, it is a response to the discovery that we are small, dependent, and not in control.

### FREUD

*"the terrifying effect of infantile helplessness aroused the need for protection... the discovery that this helplessness would continue through the whole of life made it necessary to cling to the existence of a father - but this time a more powerful one."* (F¶8) And, defining religious emotion: it is not the feeling of "man's insignificance and impotence in face of the universe" but "the reaction to it, which seeks a remedy against this feeling." (F¶11)

### LASCH

*"Religion reminds us of the inescapable limits on human power and freedom."* (L¶13) *"Rebellion against God is the natural reaction to the discovery that the world was not made for our personal convenience."* (L¶12) Modern people *"find it galling to be reminded of their dependence on powers beyond their own control."* (L¶14)

**NOTE** The same fact, human dependence, is the starting point for both. Everything else is a dispute about what religion does with that fact.

### Both distrust beliefs held because they are comforting. **AGREE**

Freud's central tool is suspicion of wish. Lasch turns out to share it: he condemns "comfortable belief" and "comfortable superstitions" in almost Freud's own words.

#### FREUD

*"we call a belief an illusion when wish-fulfillment is a prominent factor in its motivation, while disregarding its relations to reality." (F¶9) "it is very odd that this is all just as we should wish it ourselves." (F¶12)*

#### LASCH

*"it is just this comfortable belief -- that the purposes of the Almighty coincide with our purely human purposes -- that religious faith requires us to renounce." (L¶13) "Far from endorsing comfortable superstitions, it undermines the most important superstition of all." (L¶13)*

**NOTE** Lasch does not reject Freud's suspicion of wishful thinking. He claims that religion itself is the original source of that suspicion.

### Both reject a vague, softened religion that keeps the words and drops the substance. **AGREE**

Neither writer has patience for a middle ground where "God" means a mood or an abstraction and faith means feeling small.

#### FREUD

*"Philosophers stretch the meaning of words until they retain scarcely anything of their original sense: by calling 'God' some vague abstraction which they have created for themselves, they pose as deists, as believers." (F¶11) He also rejects keeping only the parts one likes: "It would be wanton to let one's own arbitrary action fill the gap." (F¶10)*

#### LASCH

Religion is not "a source of intellectual and emotional security" but "a challenge to complacency and pride." (L¶9) Faith, properly understood, is what "a long succession of prophets through the ages" taught: surrender of our claim on the universe, not a comfortable feeling. (L¶13)

**NOTE** Both want religion taken at full strength or not at all. Freud thinks full-strength religion is an illusion; Lasch thinks full-strength religion is the cure for one.

### Both treat the problem of evil and suffering as central. **AGREE, WITH OPPOSITE USES**

Freud lists the unfulfilled demand for justice as a wish that religion satisfies. Lasch says religion begins by admitting that justice is not done.

**FREUD**

*“the establishment of a moral world order ensures the fulfillment of the demands of justice, which within human culture have so often remained unfulfilled.” (F¶8)*

**LASCH**

*“The further discovery that suffering is visited on the just and unjust alike is hard to square with a belief in a benign and omnipotent creator, as we know from the Book of Job.” (L¶12) “Religious faith asserts the goodness of being in the face of suffering and evil.” (L¶11)*

**NOTE** Same fact, injustice in the world. For Freud, religion papers over it with a promised afterlife. For Lasch, the religious tradition (Job) is the place where the fact is faced most honestly.

## 2. Where they differ

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Six disagreements, in roughly the order the two texts raise them. In each case Lasch is answering a specific claim of Freud's, so the evidence lines up closely.

### Is history a story of growing up? **DIFFER**

Freud assumes that knowledge progresses and that our ancestors were more ignorant than we are, so their beliefs carry less weight. Lasch says this life-cycle picture is an "unexamined premise" and a form of pride.

**FREUD**

*“these ancestors of ours were far more ignorant than we; they believed in things we could not possibly accept today; so the possibility occurs that religious doctrines may also be in this category.” (F¶5) “it would be still odder if our poor, ignorant, enslaved ancestors had succeeded in solving all these difficult riddles of the universe.” (F¶12)*

**LASCH**

*“The unexamined premise that history can be compared to an individual's growth from childhood to maturity makes it possible to condemn any form of cultural conservatism or any respect for tradition as simply an expression of the natural human tendency to cling to the security of childhood.” (L¶2) “Disillusionment, we might say, is the characteristic form of modern pride.” (L¶6)*

**VERDICT** This is the root disagreement. Freud's argument from ancestral ignorance works for questions like the shape of the earth. Lasch's reply is that the questions religion addresses (death, evil, dependence) are not the kind that later generations solve, so "more ignorant" does not apply.

### Is doubt a modern achievement? **DIFFER**

Freud expects that people are only now learning to ask "is it true?" of religion, the way his child asked of fairy tales. Lasch argues that doubt and despair have been inside religion all along.

### FREUD

*"It is to be expected that men will soon behave in like manner towards the religious fairy tales... But at present they still behave quite differently, and in past ages... religious ideas have exercised the very strongest influence on mankind."* (F¶7)  
Questioning religion *"Formerly... was visited with the very severest penalties."* (F¶4)

### LASCH

*"What has to be questioned here is the assumption that religion ever provided a set of comprehensive and unambiguous answers... or that religious people in the past were unacquainted with existential despair."* (L¶10) The Carmina Burana, written by future priests, voice *"an age-old suspicion that the universe is ruled by Fortune, not by Providence."* (L¶10) *"The modern world has no monopoly on the fear of death or alienation from God."* (L¶12)

**VERDICT** Lasch has the historical evidence on his side here (Job, the Carmina Burana, William James's converts). Freud's picture of a past in which questioning was simply forbidden is at best incomplete.

## Does religion fulfil our wishes or attack them?

### DIFFER: THE CENTRAL REVERSAL

This is the heart of the disagreement. Freud's thesis is that religious ideas are wish-fulfillments centred on a protecting father. Lasch says the prophets taught the exact opposite: the surrender of the wish that the universe serve us.

### FREUD

*"they are illusions, fulfillments of the oldest, strongest and most insistent wishes of mankind; the secret of their strength is the strength of these wishes."* (F¶8) *"the benevolent rule of divine providence allays our anxiety in face of life's dangers."* (F¶8)

### LASCH

*"According to its critics, religion provides the security of childlike dependence of a father figure who answers all our prayers. But the naive belief that our wishes govern the universe is precisely what religion attacks. We have no special claim on the universe, and our prayers are answered only when we surrender that claim."* (L¶13) *"the secret of happiness lies in renouncing the right to be happy."* (L¶14)

**VERDICT** Notice that "father figure" and "answers all our prayers" in L¶13 are a paraphrase of F¶8. Lasch accepts Freud's description of a certain kind of religion and denies that it is the real thing. Whether he is right depends on which religion you look at: the comfort-seeking religion Freud describes exists, and so does the self-surrendering religion Lasch describes.

## What is the essence of religious feeling?

### SAME DEFINITION, OPPOSITE VALUATION

Strikingly, the two agree on what religion is a response to and then evaluate the response in opposite ways.

#### FREUD

Religion is not the feeling of insignificance itself “but rather the next step, the reaction to it, which seeks a remedy against this feeling. He who goes no further, he who humbly acquiesces in the insignificant part man plays in the universe, is, on the contrary, irreligious in the truest sense of the word.” (F¶11)

#### LASCH

“Black despair and alienation... often becomes the prelude to conversion. An awareness of “radical evil” underlies the spiritual intoxication that finally comes with “yielding” and “self-surrender.”” (L¶11) “Alienation is the normal condition of human existence.” (L¶12)

**VERDICT** For Freud, the religious move is to seek a *remedy* for insignificance, and humble acceptance is irreligious. For Lasch, following James, the religious move is humble acceptance (“yielding”). They are looking at the same moment and naming it differently. This is the most instructive contrast in the two readings, because it shows the argument is partly about definitions.

### Is science the only road to knowledge, and what does science do to us?

DIFFER

Freud treats science as the sole source of knowledge and as the force that will replace religion. Lasch treats scientific control over nature as the source of modernity's real illusion.

#### FREUD

“scientific work is our only way to the knowledge of external reality. Again, it is merely illusion to expect anything from intuition or trance.” (F¶10)  
The way to conviction about a school dogma is open because one can “go through this process oneself”; religion offers no such path. (F¶3–4)

#### LASCH

“the normal rebellion against dependence appears to be sanctioned by our scientific control over nature -- the same progress of science that has allegedly destroyed religious superstition.” (L¶15)  
“Those wonderful machines that science has enabled us to construct have made it possible to imagine ourselves as master of our fate.” (L¶16)

**VERDICT** Freud never questions whether science might produce its own illusion; Lasch never disputes that science produces knowledge. They are talking past each other slightly: Freud about method, Lasch about attitude.

### Which illusion has no future?

DIFFER: THE TITLE FIGHT

Freud's title predicts the end of religion. Lasch's title says disillusionment itself is the illusion, and that the belief in human mastery is the one now in doubt.

#### FREUD

*“we may reiterate that they are all illusions, they do not admit of proof, and no one can be compelled to consider them as true.” (F¶10) “It is to be expected that men will soon behave in like manner towards the religious fairy tales.” (F¶7)*

#### LASCH

*“In an age that fancies itself as disillusioned, this is the one illusion -- the illusion of mastery -- that remains as tenacious as ever. But now that we are beginning to grasp the limits of our control over the natural world, the future of this illusion (to invoke Freud once again) is very much in doubt -- more problematical, certainly than the future of religion.” (L¶16)*

**VERDICT** Sixty-four years separate the texts, and Freud's prediction of religion's imminent decline had not come true by 1991 (or since). Lasch's closing sentence is the sharpest single piece of evidence in the exchange.

### 3. How they work together

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It is tempting to treat the pair as a debate to be scored. The more useful reading is that each supplies what the other lacks.

- **Freud gives the method; Lasch gives the history.** Freud's error/illusion/delusion distinction (F¶9) is a genuine tool for examining any belief. Lasch's evidence (Job, the Carmina Burana, James, O'Connor) shows that the religious tradition already used a version of that tool on itself. Put together: suspicion of wish is not a modern weapon against faith; it is a discipline faith and skepticism can share.
- **Freud describes religion at its most common; Lasch describes it at its best.** Much actual religion is exactly the comfort-seeking, father-in-the-sky belief Freud analyses (F¶8), and Lasch never denies that "its critics" have something real in view (L¶13). But the prophetic and mystical strand Lasch points to is also real. A fair account of religion needs both descriptions.
- **Both are critics of self-deception, aimed in opposite directions.** Freud unmasks the believer who keeps a belief because it consoles (F¶11–12). Lasch unmasks the skeptic who keeps his skepticism because it flatters (L¶3, L¶6). Taken together, they leave no one's motives unexamined, which is the honest position.
- **Their combined lesson about dependence.** Freud is right that we cling to protectors because we are helpless (F¶8). Lasch is right that the mature response is not to deny helplessness but to stop rebelling against it (L¶15). The synthesis is a worldview that admits dependence, refuses fantasies of control, and then decides, with eyes open,

whether to trust anything beyond itself. Freud stops at the refusal; Lasch argues that the tradition goes one step further.

- **Where they truly cannot be reconciled.** Freud holds that reason is the final court and science the only knowledge (F¶6, F¶10). Lasch holds that the knowledge of our limits, which no experiment supplies, is the most important knowledge there is (L¶13–14). No synthesis dissolves that difference; it is a choice about what counts as knowing.

## 4. Quick reference

| QUESTION                            | FREUD                                                                                             | LASCH                                                                                             |
|-------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| What is religion?                   | A set of dogmas demanding belief on weak authority (F¶1, F¶4).                                    | A challenge to complacency and pride; the assertion of goodness in the face of evil (L¶9, L¶11).  |
| Where does it come from?            | Wish: infantile helplessness projected onto a cosmic father (F¶8).                                | Despair and the confrontation with evil, leading to surrender (L¶11–12).                          |
| What does it do with our wishes?    | Fulfills them: providence, justice, afterlife (F¶8).                                              | Attacks them: we have no special claim on the universe (L¶13).                                    |
| Our ancestors                       | "Poor, ignorant, enslaved," unlikely to have solved the riddles (F¶12).                           | Familiar with doubt and despair; not naive children (L¶10, L¶12).                                 |
| History's shape                     | Progress of knowledge; men "cannot remain children for ever" (F¶5, quoted L¶1).                   | The life-cycle story is a myth; nostalgia and progress are twin forms of pride (L¶2, L¶6–8).      |
| Science                             | The only way to knowledge of reality (F¶10).                                                      | The sponsor of the illusion of mastery (L¶15–16).                                                 |
| Humble acceptance of insignificance | "Irreligious in the truest sense" (F¶11).                                                         | The heart of faith: "yielding," "self-surrender" (L¶11, L¶13).                                    |
| The illusion with no future         | Religion (title; F¶7, F¶10).                                                                      | Mastery; religion's future is more secure (L¶16).                                                 |
| What is modern?                     | The dawning refusal to accept fairy tales (F¶7).                                                  | A more pervasive rebellion against dependence (L¶15).                                             |
| Tone                                | Clinical, first-person anecdotes, scientific analogies (Bodensee, Foucault's pendulum, Columbus). | Historical and literary, third-person survey, quotes authorities (Jung, Krutch, James, O'Connor). |

Tip for the identification test: Freud argues from psychology and analogy and speaks in the first person ("I happen to have been there," "one of my children"). Lasch argues from history and quotation and speaks about "modernity," "the modern temper," "nostalgia," and "pride." If a passage is diagnosing a wish, it is Freud; if it is diagnosing a self-image, it is Lasch.